EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Is Man the Centre of Creation?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 4:1-2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 4 (Obedience and Disobedience, Compulsion and Justice), Introduction and Chapters 1-2

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 11 November 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Three Essays Done

Essay	Theme
1	**Creation**: the whole concept of creation
2	**Who created**: Hashem, His attributes and how we describe Him
3	**Revelation**: the Torah, its parts, the prophets who revealed it, and (last week) twelve questions on the Torah

With these three fundamentals in place (creation, what God is, and how He reveals Himself in the world), Saadia turns to **free will**.

Essay 4 in outline

- A **relatively short** essay: an introduction and **six chapters**.
- **Saadia is the very first to discuss free will systematically.** The Talmud has fleeting references to our ability to choose good, but the philosophical problems with free will begin with him.
- The famous question, in **Chapter 4**: Hashem is perfect and knows everything, including the future. **If He knows the future, how do we have free will?** Many Rishonim discussed it, and we will see their approaches.
- **"It's worked out very nicely"**: tomorrow night's Tuesday shiur on the Rambam's **Hilchot Teshuvah** reaches **Chapter 5**, which is all about free will. "So maybe a bit of repetition tonight and tomorrow, but that's just how it's fallen out."

The order of Saadia's argument

1. Before he can raise the problems, Saadia must **establish that humans have free will**. That is not a given, "especially in today's society," where many believe everything is predetermined:

we are **biologically programmed beings** acting according to instinct, upbringing and those around us.

2. Before even that, he must establish that **only humans** have free will, and so **the Torah is directed only to humans**.
3. To do that, he makes the case that **humans are the pinnacle of creation and the centre of the universe**.

Tonight: the introduction and Chapters 1 and 2, Saadia's proofs that the world was created for humans, "and the Rishonim who opposed him and disagreed with him."

Part 1: The Title of the Essay

Saadia names the essay ***avodah u-meri, tzedek ve-hekhre'ach***: **obedience and disobedience, justice and compulsion**.

As the commentators on Saadia point out, the first two words are **not precise**. Obedience and disobedience, **merits and demerits**, are really the subject of **Essay 5**. This essay is about:

- **Compulsion:** do we have free will?
- **Justice:** Hashem can reward, punish and compensate us **only justly if we have free will**. Without full free will, the whole concept of reward and punishment falls away.

The Rabbi's explanation: Saadia's goal is obedience and disobedience, the mitzvot and the *aveirot*, in Essay 5. But first he must establish that **we can choose** between good and bad.

Part 2: The Introduction: The Middle Is the Most Important

Of all the many creatures, Saadia says, we should have no doubt **for whom the universe was created**. Natural science will show us.

Whatever matters most is in the middle

When you build something, the most important part goes in the middle. Saadia brings examples from nature:

Example	Why it shows the centre matters
The seed in a fruit or plant	It is in the middle because the whole plant grows from it. Sometimes the seed itself is what we eat, like an **almond**, encased on the outside
The yolk of an egg	It is in the middle because **the chick grows from it**
The heart	It is in the middle of the body, the centre of you
The pupil	The part you see through is in the middle of the eye

"As you can see, if you haven't worked this out yet, he's clearly going towards **a geocentric universe**," the common belief until Galileo in the 1600s changed how we see the universe.

From the cosmos to man

1. **The earth is in the middle of the universe**, and the whole cosmos revolves around it. So the earth is the most important part.
2. On the earth, **water and dust are inanimate**, and **animals do not speak**. What remains is **the human**.
3. So **humans are the pinnacle and centre of the universe**.

Saadia then brings verses:

> **אנכי עשיתי ארץ ואדם עליה בראתי**, "I made the earth and created man upon it" (Yeshayahu 45:12).
> The Rabbi did not see the proof: "Yes, perhaps the human is the centre of the earth, but it doesn't necessarily mean the human is the centre of the universe."

- **The order of Bereishit**, with man created last, and the Midrash of **a king who builds a palace, furnishes it, and only then brings in its resident**. First Hashem builds a beautiful home and furnishes it, then puts you in it.

The egg: yolk or white?

There is a discussion in the Gemara over whether the chick grows from the white or the yolk, with halachic ramifications. Saadia holds it is **the yolk**; **the Ibn Ezra** says **the white**, and brings a proof from the Gemara. Participants answered that it is the yolk, since a blood spot sometimes appears there, and **Donald** later confirmed that apparently it is indeed the yolk that matters most.

Part 3: The Ibn Ezra and the Rambam Disagree

The Ibn Ezra

On the first verse of the Torah, the Ibn Ezra writes:

ואל תשים לבך לדברי הגאון שאמר שהאדם נכבד מהמלאכים

Pay no attention to the words of the Gaon, who said that man is more honoured than the angels.

In another book he went through Saadia's proofs and said **they are all incorrect**:

- **The most elevated humans are the prophets**, and yet **Yehoshua prostrated himself** and showed great deference before an angel.
- **The heart** is important, "I agree, but **the head** is as important, if not more." And the head is not in the middle.
- **The seed:** that works for an almond, where the edible seed is in the middle. But in **grapes** and other fruit, the seed in the middle is **inedible**, and the important part is **the fruit around it**.

Saadia's premise is gone

"Nowadays we would say that Saadia is clearly incorrect. We may not be comfortable saying that, but that's the reality." Even if we accept his premise that the middle is the most important, which the Ibn Ezra disputed, **the earth is not the middle**. Everything does not revolve around the earth; we are **a speck** in a huge universe, and if anything we revolve around the sun. The Rambam and the Ibn Ezra could not raise this, living in a pre-heliocentric world. "It could well be that humans are the pinnacle of creation, but not because of Saadia's proofs."

The Rambam: Moreh Nevuchim 3:13

The Rambam did not believe humans were the pinnacle of creation.

- **You may think** everything in the universe exists for man, and some verses suggest it, such as **לא תהו בראה, לשבת יצרה**, "He did not create it for emptiness; He formed it to be inhabited" (Yeshayahu 45:18).
- **But analyse it.** "We have a duty always to analyse our thoughts and opinions." **Could Hashem have created the human without all the cosmos around us?** Of course He could. We don't need all the galaxies. So what are they for?
- **And even if you said the universe is for man**, the question remains: what is **the purpose of man serving God**? "This is a famous paragraph, by the way." God gains nothing from our service. If you say it is for us, to perfect ourselves, why is our perfection important? And so on.
- **The conclusion:** you will go back endlessly, and must stop somewhere: **so Hashem desired, so His wisdom decreed**. The Rabbi linked it to **Ne'ilah**, where we say that Hashem set man apart from the beginning, and **who can say to Him, what are You doing?** "It's just Hashem wanted to do so."

	Was the universe created for man?
Saadia	**Yes.** Man is the centre and pinnacle, and everything is for him
The Ibn Ezra	**No.** Saadia's proofs are all incorrect, and the angels are higher
The Rambam	**No.** Hashem did not need the cosmos for man; ultimately, **that was His will**

The rest of the essay still stands. "Regardless of whether you believe like Saadia or like the Rambam, the free will discussions we're going to have are still true and still correct."

From the class: the Milky Way and beyond

A participant asked whether God created the Milky Way too. The Rabbi: everyone agrees He created everything. The Milky Way is our galaxy, and there are millions or billions of others, each with its systems and stars.

"It's very funny, because at the end of Chapter 1 Saadia says: **don't think I believe the universe was created for humans out of human arrogance**; it's because of all the objective proofs. I think if Saadia were around today and knew its vastness, it would be much harder to argue that **all of this is just for humans**. There must be something else going on. Why? I've got no idea. This is the will of Hashem."

Asked whether there might be **more gods** in the Milky Way: "**Absolutely not.** God forbid, there is one God." But whether there are other populations or creatures in another galaxy, "that could well be, we don't know. In fact some of our Rabbis did believe there were. A talk for another time." To a joke about Elon Musks on other galaxies sending satellites: "Maybe one day. We'll see."

Part 4: Chapter 1, Why Man Was Given Choice

With the introduction aside, Saadia says the prophets told us **humans are the most important**:

- **Tehillim 8**: "You have made him **little less than the angels**... You have given him dominion over the works of Your hands," the fish of the sea and the beasts. "The whole Psalm talks about

how amazing humans are."
- Hashem gave us the ability to work the land and control over the earth.

Because we are the pinnacle, **He gave us the choice**, and commanded us to choose good:

ראה נתתי לפניך היום את החיים ואת הטוב ואת המות ואת הרע... ובחרת בחיים

See, I have set before you today life and good, death and evil... **and you shall choose life.** (Devarim 30:15, 19)

And we accept it because the Torah was proven through the prophets and their miracles.

The Rabbi noted that **the Ibn Ezra would agree** that humans have a certain authority over the animals, as the Torah says. The question is only whether **everything was created for man**.

In what way are we better? Wisdom

Through our **wisdom**:

- We **remember the past** and **think about the future**.
- We have made animals **work for us** and produce for us.
- We **draw and irrigate water**, and even build **water wheels** that draw it by themselves, without our labour.
- We build beautiful **homes**, make beautiful **clothes**, and **cook**, blending flavours to please the palate.
- We form **armies, encampments and kingdoms**.
- We study **astronomy**: how far each planet is from the next.

"If you think there's another creature with all of this, **show me**. You're not going to find it." So man is **the root and foundation of the world**, and to him are directed **the commandments, the prohibitions, and the consequences** for good and bad.

"Not my arrogance." Saadia insists: when I say man is more important than all else, **it is not a mistake, and not my arrogance or brazenness**. It is clear and correct. Hashem gave us this advantage so that we would be the ones to whom the mitzvot are given, for **the root of all is the fear of Hashem**.

Introduction and Chapter 1 compared

	The claim	Do the Ibn Ezra and the Rambam agree?
Introduction	The earth, and so man, is most important **because it is in the centre**	**No.** The centre is not necessarily the most important, and we are not in the centre
Chapter 1	Man has **an advantage over other creatures: wisdom**, and therefore receives the commandments	**It could well be** that they agree

In the middle of all this Saadia slips in one key sentence: **we have the ability to choose**, and so we must choose in life.

From the class: speech

A participant added that **we are the only ones who can talk**. The Rabbi: animals do express themselves, with barks and meows ("maybe dogs think that we bark"), and dolphins communicate very well. But **we have speech**, and many languages. "That's another thing you could say is a proof of how the human is higher than everything else."

Part 5: Chapter 2, Eight Questions on Man's Greatness

"I'm going to do this really quickly, because the real essay on free will starts in Chapter 3." Having established man as the pinnacle, Saadia asks **eight questions** on it.

1. Why is man so small?

All of this, for us tiny beings? **Our body is small, but our mind and consciousness are greater than heaven and earth.** Physically we can only run, or get on a plane. But our minds can think about what is happening **in Australia**, beyond this planet, and even **about God**. "Physically small, but spiritually very great and very vast."

2. Why don't we live longer?

The Rabbi put it to the class. One answer was that we once did live long; another, that the Torah says **"on the day you eat of it you shall die."**

Saadia's answer: Hashem gave us **a short life in this world, the life of work**, and in the future we will have **the continuous life** (he will discuss resurrection in Essay 9). This world is the life of **achievement**, so it must be limited, and the reward comes in the World to Come.

"Why does Saadia not give the answer the Torah gives?" A participant said: who says it's a different answer? "Exactly. That's it." Before Adam sinned he lived in Eden, in what we would call **the World to Come**. After the sin he had to go through death, and receive the World to Come in a different state. Saadia is **explaining in words people will understand** what the Torah means.

"That's the beauty of Saadia. He can't just give an answer because the Torah says so. It's amazing he's writing this 1,100 years ago. He could have said the Torah says, but that's not good enough for the people he was addressing."

3. Why is our body so feeble?

We are made of blood and phlegm, full of excesses. Why not more refined? **Man is already the most refined of all the creatures.** Anything more refined would be **an angel**. Asking for a more refined human is like asking for heaven made of dust or earth made of fire: you are asking for there to be **no heaven, no earth, no human**. "You're just saying nonsense."

A participant pointed to Tehillim 8, **"a little less than the angels."** "Very good, that's precisely correct," and Saadia quoted that Psalm in Chapter 1. The Rabbi compared it to a remark of the Rambam's: why is the sky blue? Because it is blue. If it were green, you'd ask why it is green. "This is the human. If you want a different kind of human, it's not the human anymore."

4. Why illnesses?

Flu, colds, the big ones. **Through our pains we are humbled and aroused to return to Hashem** as we lie in bed. "And there's a lot of truth to that, by the way."

"When we're fit, healthy, wealthy, everything's perfect, what do I need God for? You know the story of the guy who comes to synagogue on Yom Kippur for the final half an hour and says: God, I had a fantastic year, please just stay out of it for the coming year."

"**There's no atheist in the foxhole.** When you're in bed, in hospital, when things have gone terribly wrong, suddenly you open up your tefillin and pray." If a person keeps the connection with Hashem when everything is going well, **Hashem doesn't need to bring these things**. He brings them to people who need reminding, "and many of us need these reminders."

5. Why are we exposed to heat, cold and dangerous animals?

Snakes, lions that can eat you, elephants that can throw you around. **So that we know what Hashem's punishments could be.** If there were nothing to fear, a person told "I'll punish you" would say, "What can You do to me?"

- **Malachi:** a day is coming **burning like an oven**. We need to know scorching heat to grasp it.
- **Ha'azinu:** when we do wrong and the nations turn against us, their punishments will be like **the venom of serpents**. "I need to know what the venom of a serpent is."

6. Why so many cravings and desires?

So that we learn to choose correctly how and when to use them:

Desire	Its proper use	Its misuse
Money	To live properly	Stealing and cheating
Food	Looking after the body	Eating the wrong things
Relations	Bringing the next generation, as Hashem instructed	Passion for women forbidden to him

"The *rasha* is happy about all his desires." Hashem creates the cravings so we can choose between the good uses and the bad.

7. Why punishment, and not just no reward?

"This is interesting. I think there's a bit of depth there." The Rabbi recalled the **Ramchal** from Derech Hashem: Hashem created the world **to bestow goodness**, and we must be **the authors of our own identity** by choosing good. The question everyone asks: fine, those who choose good are rewarded with Olam HaBa. Those who don't simply **lose the opportunity**. Why the **fire of Gehinnom**? If it purifies, fine; but endless suffering, why?

Rabbeinu Yonah writes, and the Rabbi took this as Saadia's point too: **if there were nothing to fear, there would be no incentive.** If doing good brings reward and not doing it costs nothing, "life's good anyway, maybe I'll do it." When you know there will be consequences, "I have to do it."

8. How can the Torah execute a human being?

(Saadia counts seven questions; this eighth continues the seventh.) If man is so important, how can some sins carry **the death penalty**? Saadia: when **a limb is poisoned**, it is right to **amputate** it to save the body. So too with the human race. One who commits such a sin has corrupted himself and may corrupt the species, so he is removed **so that the rest can continue to live**.

Saadia ends: any other question you have, think about it and you will find an answer. **Everything Hashem does is correct.**

#	Question	Saadia's answer
1	Why is man so small?	The body is small; the mind is vast
2	Why so short a life?	This is the life of work; the life of reward is long and constant
3	Why so feeble a body?	It is the best body; any better would be an angel
4	Why illness?	To awaken us to teshuvah
5	Why dangers in nature?	So we can grasp what punishment means
6	Why cravings?	To learn to use them rightly
7	Why punishment, not just loss?	Fear gives the incentive to choose rightly
8	Why execution?	Amputating a poisoned limb to save the body

Summary

1. **Essay 4 is about free will**, and Saadia is **the first** to treat it systematically. The famous question of **foreknowledge** comes in Chapter 4.
2. **The title** names obedience and disobedience, but those are really Essay 5's subject. This essay is about **compulsion and justice**: reward and punishment are just only if we choose freely.
3. **The introduction** argues that **the centre is always most important** (seed, yolk, heart, pupil) and **the earth is the centre**, so man is the purpose of creation. The **Ibn Ezra** rejects every proof; the **Rambam** (Moreh 3:13) says the cosmos was not needed for man and in the end it was **Hashem's will**. Today, with the earth a speck in a vast universe, Saadia's premise is plainly wrong, but the essay's discussion of free will stands either way.
4. **Chapter 1:** man's advantage is **wisdom**, so he receives the commandments and **the power to choose**: "choose life." "Not my arrogance," says Saadia.
5. **Chapter 2:** eight questions on man's greatness, from his small body to the death penalty, each answered.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** Chapter 3 and some of Chapter 4: the dynamics of free will, and then **the contradiction between free will and foreknowledge**.
- **Tomorrow night:** the Tuesday shiur on the Rambam's Hilchot Teshuvah, Chapter 5, on free will.

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